



Rewarding campaign: R. Smaran shone brightly as the breakout star for Karnataka in the 2024-25 Vijay Hazare Trophy. THE HINDU

"I want to see where Karnataka is going to be in the next two to three years. There are a lot of talented boys, and this is the right time to give them a chance and groom them. All the youngsters have done exceedingly well, and you can see the results. There are still a lot of young guys in the Under-19 and U-23 levels, so the bench strength in Karnataka cricket is very good," he told Sportstar. "Smaran has impressed the most. We have seen him as a U-14 boy, and we really backed him.

He got close to 700 [829] runs last year [in U-23 Col. CK Nayudu Trophy], and I am glad that he has done very well. Aneesh, he has gotten out early in his 20s and 30s,

but he has the talent to do well. Last year, he almost got close to 1000 [922] runs. We have a bunch of fast bowlers — Abhilash Shetty has done very well, and Vidyadhar [Patil] has done well. We have Hardik Raj. Karnataka cricket is in very good hands now," he added.

Karnataka had also moved on from its former skipper, Karun Nair, back in 2022, but the 33-year-old's career gained a second wind during Vidarbha's maiden run to the final of the 50-over competition. **While shouldering captaincy duties in his second season with the side, Karun tallied a whopping 779 runs in nine matches while averaging 389.50.**

However, as fate would have it, his stupendous run of five consecutive 50-plus scores — which included four centuries — ended in the final with a 31-ball 27 against his former side. That his team's defeat in the final coincided with his non-selection in India's squad for

the upcoming ICC Champions Trophy was a reminder that fairytales are few and far between.

With the lines between one-day and T20 cricket blurring increasingly, the 2024-25 Vijay Hazare Trophy was the second-fastest scoring season in the tournament's history.

Runs were scored at an average of 5.20 per over, the 400-run barrier was breached four times, and leading the charge was Punjab — the 2023-24 champion of the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, the domestic T20 tournament. With two totals in excess of 400 in the season, the Punjab line-up, led by openers Prabhsimran Singh and Abhishek Sharma, ransacked bowling attacks by scoring runs at an average of 6.77 runs an over.

Prabhsimran and Abhishek struck at 128.68 and 130.44 during the tournament, respectively, further pointing to the evolution of